

Indian Government Opts for Open Source in New Policy!

Open source experts are quite in favour of the new policy and believe this is the right move on the government's part. However, they caution that it must be implemented with extra care for the best impact.

Open source technology is set to make a strong impact in India. An all-new policy on open source software is the latest addition in the Indian government's initiatives towards making the country more tech-savvy. Under this new policy, all government software applications are to be switched to open source, leading to huge savings and marking an end to the use of proprietary software.

A part of the 'Digital India' initiative

The policy is being adopted as a part of the Indian government's 'Digital India' initiative, which will ensure more effective governance for the citizens of this country. This initiative will make government services accessible to citizens across the nation, digitally, which means the paperwork will be reduced gradually. Rural areas will also be connected through high-speed Internet, as a part of this project. The newly adopted open source policy will have a strong influence on this initiative.

The rapid spread of e-governance in the country

E-governance is on in full swing across the country, and information and communication technology has become an integral part of government services. The aim is to build a better network between the common people of India and the Central as well as state governments. As Venkatesh Swaminathan, country head, The Attachmate Group India (Novell, SUSE, NetIQ, Attachmate), puts it, "State governments have already started lots of e-governance initiatives, and it has spread across services like land records, birth and death registrations, and even the provident fund."

A GitHub-like repository for open sourcing code

With the open source policy coming into effect, the government will also create a GitHub-like repository for all open source software. This will allow developers to contribute to the projects in collaboration with each other, as the code of the software will be shared for all. If collaborative development is encouraged further, it will become easier to use open source software whenever and wherever required. More applications will be derived from this kind of collaborative development.

A cost-effective measure

Millions of dollars are expected to be saved on the purchase of IT products and related services, once the open source policy is adopted effectively in the offices of the Indian government. The implementation of this open source policy will prove highly

cost-effective for the government as, whenever the government requires any software product, it will not need to pay for it any more. This will consequently have an impact on the savings strategy of the Indian government.

Open source in the government sector is not a new concept

The use of open source in government software applications began long ago. Swaminathan says, "The government is also working with its internal agencies to develop open source offerings. It has taken up a lot of initiatives, specifically to develop applications on open source technology, to provide them on an enterprise-class scale along with the underlying infrastructure, as the software can be managed, patched and is secure." He also says that open source projects can be very successful across sectors like education, defence-related projects like DRDO, and more.

What's so special about the new Open Source Policy?

According to the Department of Electronics and Information Technology (DeitY), the new policy will allow the source code of any software application to be modified by a user, as per individual requirements. The common repository will help in reducing duplication of applications too. If any government agency or department wants to use any particular application in its own way, then customisation of the code will become easier through this common repository. The new policy will also help to speed up the deployment of IT. Open source experts are quite in favour of the new policy as they believe this is a right move on the government's part. But they warn that extra care must be taken in the implementation of the policy, to ensure the best impact.

According to Swaminathan, the best qualities of open source technology are its flexibility and the wide choice it offers. Proprietary technologies demand complete dependence on the software vendor for all the solutions as well as developments, while open source technology is unquestionably open for all. He is also hopeful that the new policy, "...will offer the best benefits to people, whom the government is serving, and it will also be great for netizens like us who're able to access these services." Apart from creating an e-literate society and boosting savings, the policy is also aimed at accelerating the digital drive across the country. 

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